

Q Where can I find out about maternity (or paternity), benefits at work?

In the US, there are no laws in place ensuring that women receive paid maternity leave. The same goes for paternity leave. Policies vary at different companies, so it depends on your individual workplace as to whether or not you'll be eligible. Even if you are, the percentage of your salary that you'll receive, and the number of weeks you'll receive it, will vary by the company. Sometimes it depends on your length of tenure with your company. Your company may also allow you to use sick days or vacation days that you've accumulated to stay home with your baby. During your pregnancy, speak with your boss and/or your human resources manager to determine your eligibility for paid maternity leave and/or using sick or vacation days. A handful of states, including California, offer paid maternity leave for new parents. This may be partial pay for a few weeks' time.

Q When should I tell my employer that I'm pregnant?

Many women wait until they're 12 weeks pregnant before they share the news with anyone but immediate family. However, you may work in an environment that could be hazardous to your pregnancy. For example, if you're a dentist or doctor working with X-rays, or a hairdresser coming into contact with lots of chemicals, or if you're suffering from severe morning sickness and it's stopping you from doing your job properly, it's a good idea to tell

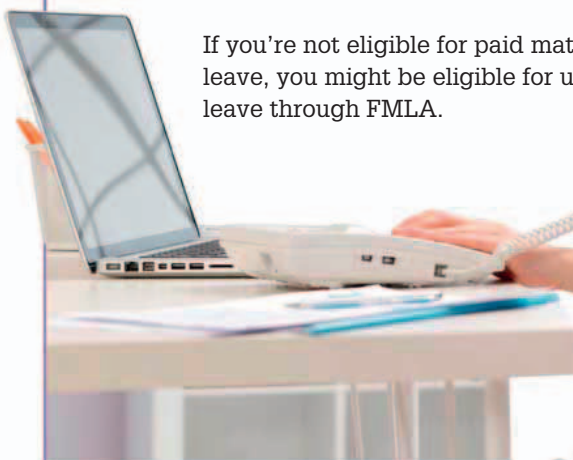


Did you know...

As soon as you let your employer know you're pregnant, ask for a copy of your company's maternity policy. If your company doesn't offer paid maternity leave, go online to read about the Family and Medical Leave Act (FMLA), which you can use to spend time with your baby without fear of losing your job.

Q What is the Family and Medical Leave Act (FMLA)?

If you're not eligible for paid maternity leave, you might be eligible for unpaid leave through FMLA.



You'll be able to take time off from work—up to 12 weeks in a 12-month period. Your employer is required to hold your job (or a similar one) for you during that time frame and continue your health insurance coverage at the same rate. To qualify, you'll need to have worked for your company for at least 12 months and at least 1,250 hours during the past 12 months. You'll also have

to work within 75 miles of offices where 50 or more of your company's employees work. (FMLA does not apply to very small companies.) If you meet the FMLA criteria, you're eligible for these benefits—whether you're male or female and whether you work for a private company or state or local government. (Some federal employees are also eligible.)

your employer sooner. Many women don't feel comfortable sharing the news about their pregnancy until their belly shows, around 20 weeks. Share your news with your boss before your friends. You need to remain on excellent terms with your boss, whom you'll work with when it's time to delegate your responsibilities to others when you need time off when your baby arrives. Don't let your boss learn about your pregnancy through the grapevine, if the office gossips hear about it first.

Most fathers-to-be who want to take time off from work to spend time with their newborns when they arrive have to use their accumulated vacation days or sick time. Have your partner check with his boss or human resources department representative to see if he can use vacation or sick leave in this way. Even if your partner is able to do this, his company may not want him to take more than a week or two off from work at a time for this purpose.

Q What can my partner expect in terms of paternity leave?

Although more companies offer paternity leave to their male employees than a decade ago, paternal leave still isn't a widespread practice at businesses nationwide. Of course policies vary by the company. Some may offer paid time off, while others may offer unpaid or reduced pay during paternity leave.

Q My job is really high pressure. Is stress bad for my baby?

It is always a good idea to take steps to manage stress and anxiety. It is thought that the stress hormones cortisol and adrenaline can pass from you to your baby (studies have found both of these hormones in the amniotic fluid of stressed mothers). Some studies show that stress can increase the risk of premature birth, or of